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Conclusion: Democratic Innovations after the Beginning

To understand why citizen participation in politics succeeds and fails, this book has focused on participatory budgeting, probably the most well-known democratic innovation worldwide. I have traced the development of comparative work on PB as the innovation has diffused and as knowledge of the field has developed. I was motivated to figure out under what circumstances citizens involved in programmes designed to engage them in governance gain meaningful control of important collective decisions. I have shown that as the field of democratic innovation, and in particular, PB, matures, significant steps have been taken in the direction of a more systematic comparison providing ever better answers to that question.

Parts II and III presented and discussed practical issues involved in undertaking advanced QCA across cases. I argued that we can better understand participatory democracy by allowing an assessment of the value and potential of cumulating existing knowledge using systematic formal logic. My aim was never to undercut other approaches or extol the virtues of one approach, but rather to provide a new complementary approach. Up to now research has focused on in-depth qualitative small-N research, or large-N studies that either focus on individuals as the unit of analysis or on breadth at the expense of depth. The value of robust and general findings is that they can allow relevant actors – civil society activists, political leaders and even academics – to plan their actions with a degree of confidence in the lessons of evidence. My work offers notable improvements in our understanding of participatory democracy, and I identify complementary tools of analysis that should be of use to those interested in furthering their knowledge of PB. The QCA approach to cumulating and systematically reviewing the evidence of previous research reveals redundant elements of causal

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claims or identifies oversimplification. I conclude here by outlining the key findings and their implications for the theory and practice of democracy.

Looking back before looking forward

In introducing the book, I outlined a set of key wider debates that the work presented here will contribute to. I certainly did not need to demonstrate that highly democratic outcomes are achievable in PB programmes – that has been done before – but I have shown that these democratic improvements are relatively widely spread, varying in both their number and qualities. I have argued throughout that we need to take the conceptualization of participatory programmes, including PB, seriously, and we should not be afraid of understanding the full range of cases and their outcomes. I outlined the consequences for causal interpretation of narrower conceptualizations of successful outcomes in PB. Of course, our understanding of what constitutes a success is grounded in normative as well as conceptual theory, and cannot simply be understood by measurement. It can help us, however, if we can articulate more systematically what is at stake in different conceptualizations. I have shown that some standards may be too high – contrary to what is implied by much of the previous literature on the topic of PB, there are few, if any, single necessary causal conditions that explain successful citizen control in participatory decision-making.

Instead, the most important contribution is in explaining how PB programme outcomes vary across cases. My comparison provides some specific combinations that may alternatively produce good outcomes. Instigators and adopters of participatory programmes should think about the contexts in which they innovate and what they know works in such contexts. Political leaders' commitment to participation in words and deeds is a necessary condition for citizens to gain meaningful control of collective decisions (accepting some minor caveats that the absence of leadership can be overcome in the short term). By corollary, where this commitment is absent, failures are almost ubiquitous. Any hope for successful programmes where politicians' commitment is absent is extinguished completely when either other relevant actors are not minded to support the process or where the entity running the programme faces financial constraints.

Where civil society retains autonomy and acts both in contention and concert with willing political leaders, and bureaucratic staff are able and willing to support the process, this combination of factors is sufficient for success, regardless of financial challenges. Where key actors are

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able to work together, they can find ways to overcome challenges. I would also hold that this is the best opportunity to break through the 'glass ceiling' where a critical mass of power transfer can lead citizens to really consider the injustice in existing institutional relationships. This explanation sets a high standard for successful participation, and will be favoured by those who prefer solutions where risks are more clearly articulated. These are, perhaps, the 'real utopias' once envisaged by Erik Olin Wright and colleagues.

Nevertheless, and perhaps controversially, there is also relatively good evidence that civil society may be less relevant to explanations of successful outcomes. In almost all cases where leaders commit to programmes, a combination with a strong financial position alone, or with strong bureaucratic buy-in alone, is sufficient for empowered democratic decision-making. The caveat comes in that there are a small group of cases that strongly contradict this last statement, but they do so in very idiosyncratic ways. These represent middling cases where leaders are committed to inculcating participatory norms but end up with less than good but not egregious democratic outputs. They provide an important puzzle for future research. In particular, theory-generating or clarifying studies may want to revisit the question of what role the state can play in shaping civil society through participatory politics.

The cumulation of cases can serve to increase the options available for democratic reformers who wish to bring about transformational outcomes by helping them to consider the most effective potential strategies for changing the contexts they wish to intervene in. Future studies will also want to build on this research to accumulate data on cases over the long term. I have outlined a set of wider questions that will provide avenues for more specific data collection that can complement existing findings. The cumulative qualitative approach I favour here has been useful in furthering development of a field of study and outlining what is at stake when scoping concepts. I harnessed the strength of previous casework and accumulated that knowledge to try to provide a more parsimonious statement about what causal processes are at work in a sample of some of the most well-known and well-studied cases of PB.

Expanding comparisons of democratic innovations

The question of comparability of cases is one that constantly troubles researchers in the emerging field of democratic innovations. That inquisition is a good sign. Lijphart notes that comparative politics makes progress 'as a result of the efforts of the field's innovators to

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fashion universally applicable vocabularies of basic politically relevant concepts' (1971: 686), and as Mill put it, the 'general conception is itself obtained by a comparison of particular phenomena' (1950: 298). The most transparent way to know the relevant level of abstraction at which phenomena are comparable without resorting to conceptual stretching is to examine and list their key properties and to compare them. This basic method of identifying the intension and extension of a concept should be no different for social or physical scientific research. What is different in social research is that the observation of these characteristics is more usually a matter of degree, and we often have to live with greater levels of uncertainty. This difference in certainties should not hamper efforts unduly. When it is more difficult to pin down and clearly observe these characteristics, especially in the early stages of phenomenological development, in order to progress our understanding, we need to cumulate knowledge systematically by comparison. A cumulative comparison can be conscious of the accuracy of conceptual delineation. We require a research agenda that marries sensitivity to theory and conceptual clarity, with sensitivity to accuracy in observations of practices, and with sensitivity to appropriate methods of inferential comparison. My work here can plug some gaps in such a research agenda.

I have been interested in testing hegemonic claims about what kinds of democratic innovation best achieve democratic outcomes (see, for example, Fishkin, 2009), with claims that plural approaches to democracy may achieve comparable combinations of democratic goods (Smith, 2009). Democratic theorists have been prone to hegemonic claims about whether mass participation can or cannot work in this or that context. I have shown that successful participation is not a matter of absolutes, but a matter of context. This is not to introduce 'matter of degree phraseology'. It may be that 'competing' theories of democratic empowerment are, in fact, not really competing but try to explain different specific contexts without a tool for identifying adequate trade-offs in parsimony and complexity. Only through comparative analysis can we iterate between and assess these claims effectively. My analysis of key factors used to explain democratic PB outcomes suggests that they are characterized by equifinality. I think we should expect democratic outcomes to vary within and across designs, but hope that we can continue to reduce uncertainty around factors that may predict those outcomes. The successful cases here can, in some instances, confirm or deny a number of 'competing' theories of democracy and governance and show that others are not in competition. Yet, as I have

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detailed, even a 'within-type-of-innovation' comparative design ran up against important revealing questions of a definition of what PB is and what we should expect from it. If anything, we seem to be biased as a social research community to lay the burden of proof such that the comparativist must prove that two or more cases are comparable rather than incomparable. For comparativists there is a certain pressure not to compare 'the incomparable' – to narrow the scope of their research and to favour case-based research on most-similar systems. While there is much rationale in these ideas, they should not dominate at the expense of more ecumenical or abstract comparisons that seek answers to interesting questions. It is by regularly comparing across cases that we actually find out how far apart things are (and challenge received wisdom in a changing world).

There are, for example, ongoing questions of what is or is not a mini-public (Fishkin, 2009; Ryan and Smith, 2014). Warren (2009) speaks of possibly over 100 named processes of governance-driven democratization, and many more have emerged since Warren's work was published. The pressure to innovate can lead so-called innovators to be keen to distinguish this or that as an invention. There is a worry that incentives for action in such a direction come at the expense of identification of devices that are common to good outcomes and therefore prevent replication of best practice across cases, or understanding of broad contexts where one design might (not) fit. It is essential that when we build a field of research as social scientists, we, too, are aware of biases that work to privilege methods that highlight the uniqueness of events. As an antidote we need methods that cumulate research in a way that is sensitive to holistic case research and ideally involves bringing researchers together efficiently to produce robust research. QCA approaches are at least relatively transparent in their operationalization of concepts and the ways in which they are seen to transverse. We should look for methods that can supplement such an approach.

There are several opportunities now to build on the knowledge provided and to see if the findings that hold for PB across these cases also hold across others. Further work might also be able to apply some of the time-sensitive QCA methods being developed to test sequencing of democratic innovations and/or the use of technology in PDIs. Deviant cases or new cases that mimic deviant conditions should be investigated, and there may also be interesting opportunities to integrate large-N data collection with case research to explain the death and resurrection of participatory projects.

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Methods and methodologies in research on participatory democratic innovations

The number of cases I have studied here is still relatively unusual. I found that refreshing. Most researchers have a fairly strong unifying theory about how small-N or large-N research contributes to theory formation, but their presuppositions can sometimes crack if you push them into medium-N territory. Research on PDIs has been quite commendable in its conscious efforts to continue dialogue between ideas and evidence. The perhaps unusual road I have travelled, taking on the study of a medium-N of cases, is not one that provides a 'best of both worlds' for research approaches, but it does provide some correctives and enlightening insights that may not otherwise be easy to come by. The QCA approach allowed for interplay between induction and deduction and a flexible but robust theoretical framework. The problematization of concepts and qualitative variation was evidence-based, but at the same time concerns about replicability, logical calculation and extrapolation were accounted for with relative transparency. The approach can only ever be part of a broader collaborative research effort. I have highlighted kinds of cases that need further attention from ethnographers or conditions that need to be tested across a larger-N, perhaps through systematic correlation using more accessible proxies.

I have shown that a procedure that uses systematic Boolean logic when constructing research design can be useful to derive typologies similar to the method envisaged by George and Bennett (2005: 257). This had not been tried before to such an extent in the field of participatory innovation. The presentation of the calibration and truth table also prompts thought experiments and theoretical work that can try to explain why we do not have empirical instances of key factors or many contradictory instances of others. I have even shown that the logical approach that QCA provides could be effectively utilized by researchers studying a small number of cases in order to check whether their conclusions rely too much on intuition. QCA seems a good method for systematically reviewing the best evidence we have on a given phenomenon. I suggest that expert surveys might avail of some of these tools to incorporate qualitative evaluations of cases in a more systematic way.

Yet many things remain unclear. There may be a worry that constructing research in the way I have done still falls foul of subjectivity – an unsympathetic critic might say I mask uncertainty and subjectivity behind a veneer of unfamiliar language and mathematical

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operations. I think that would be to go too far; I certainly thought hard about whether I was sterilizing qualitative research, but I cannot make any special claims to have interpreted raw materials any more objectively than another capable reader might. It is important to open up a discussion about how we can improve the accuracy and transparency of inferences. We cannot remove judgements but we need to make our reasons explicit in a way that allows others to engage with them.[1] Transparency, I have argued, is paramount for research, but is particularly important when interpreting the work of others. In some ways there can be an initial cost to transparency in using QCA, as with any method that introduces new information and jargon, because there is some cost to others to identifying its message. Moreover, I often rearranged cases' memberships according to the requests made by case researchers where they saw me present my work. Building on the fuzzy maps, I would, in future, like to develop tools that may allow crowd interaction among researchers while sorting and discussing case calibration with swift recourse to the evidence. In the end it will require further engagement among colleagues to answer some of these questions.

There may be good arguments for avoiding these research strategies. Lieberson (1994) is quick to point out that Mill himself, on whose lucidity the comparative method is grounded, was sceptical of using such a method in the social sciences.[2] Thoughtful critiques from this school have shot difficult charges at case-based research strategies, perhaps most convincingly when rounding on their perceived inability to distinguish random from real data and adequately consider measurement error (Hug, 2013; Lucas and Szatrowski, 2014; Krogslund et al, 2015; Paine, 2016). Such critiques of case-based research have helped improve our understanding of their value immensely, but their dismissal of small-N strategies is based on a focus on technique over approach. The lasting criticism of King, Keohane and Verba's work (1994) is that it tries to impose variable-oriented thinking on case-based research strategies. 'Variable-oriented' and 'case-based' are really shorthand here for different underlying assumptions about the nature of the world at any one time, or at least what kinds of uncertainty we are willing to prefer in explanations of the social world. Critiques are not ignoble, and their lessons provide a useful check on unreflective 'small' thinking. The contributions of Schneider (2016), and Thiem

[1] My thanks to David Owen for helping me clarify this point more eloquently.

[2] For a simple explanation of Mill's methods and a connection to Boolean logic, see Ryan (2018).

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and Baumgartner (2016) have, however, helped to clarify and elucidate the intrinsic value of case-based and analytical set-theoretic research strategies. Neither is the QCA approach immune from critique. Stark differences among QCA's defenders on that score testify to it. Certainly case-based approaches can incentivize an over-reliance on designs that too easily latch on to a particular pattern in a case, which influences how a researcher considers variance that is only perceived. But this is a similar psychological issue for modelling in large-N research; it just manifests a little differently. We need to better understand our own biased anchors that we cling to in all research approaches.

As I hope I have shown, small-N research can create incentives that restrict researchers too quickly to claims of exceptionalism. Analyses that highlight exceptionality are not necessarily problematic and can be quite powerful, but they should not be the norm. The true explanation for avoidance of medium-N strategies is not difficult to imagine. Small-N approaches rely on a high quality of information about and familiarity with cases in a study. And it is simply very difficult for a researcher, possessed with only one brain, to have a deep understanding of many cases. Trade-offs are necessary. Lijphart's words still ring true: '... awareness of the limitations of the comparative method is necessary but need not be disabling' (1971: 685). The question, then, becomes one of developing coping or enhancement strategies for small-N research, or at least applying the comparative method in a way that has potential to contribute to generalization. Collaborations among small-N researchers are often a good idea, and I have highlighted some very successful ones among PB researchers. Perhaps I can persuade them to make use of tools for more systematic comparisons.

The research presented in this book does two things that are not fashionable, but should be. Rather than search for 'new' examples of public policy innovations, it tries to bring together existing research and, in the end, provides new insights. Second, it produces research in a way it can be added to transparently, and easily replicated. In fact, it tries to replicate some previous analyses, testing them with a new method. I will welcome wholeheartedly ongoing critique from case researchers and others as the point of this work is to prompt that discussion.

The future for participatory budgeting and participatory democracy

Participatory democratic innovation has matured as a field of study, but this is the end of the beginning. A large industry of innovators and public participation professionals has developed who both advocate

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for and implement processes like PB. Moreover, all over the world, several administrators, civil society activists, politicians, and, of course, citizens who never engaged in politics have had experiences with PB both good and bad. Like many democratic innovations in this era of governance-driven democratization, the number of PB processes worldwide continues to grow. It seems for now that PB is here to stay as a phenomenon, even though it has not remained in many places. PB still faces many opponents and a lot of uncertainty.

An important long-term challenge I have not been able to focus on up to now is worth highlighting. The challenge of long-term financial planning has not yet really been overcome. Many participatory budgets seem to run into difficulty when returns to scale reduce and implementation failure increases. Efforts to involve PB participants in some kind of long-term decision-making, for example, in Santo André, did not really work. Long-term decision-making can be disappointing if it simply means kicking the can down the road. Designers should consider this issue, particularly with the unsustainability of human life based on our current decisions becoming an ever more alarming prospect. Participatory programmes often seem to suffer because monitoring and implementation is an afterthought, and when that point of a cycle is reached, funds have already been used up. Where processes fail in delivering accountability and long-term security for participants, one cannot blame them for wondering whether the joke is on them for believing these processes can deliver. But perhaps we should not be surprised – few, if any, political decision-making procedures have a good record in making decisions for the long term, or on monitoring and implementation. The last point, however, also highlights how overclaiming the potential of any programme to deliver can be dangerous.

Democratic innovation is often seen as a response to democratic deficits, but it is not yet clear that it has actually responded. Politics in general appears increasingly characterized by populism and polarization. Frankly, participatory innovation has failed to really engage the disengaged in a way that elections and referendums have continued to do. While some participatory budgets are good examples of including otherwise disengaged voices, others exacerbate alienation and anger with political process. The reality is that populism is engaging more citizens than participatory and deliberative democracy right now. Perhaps in my bleakest moments I felt I was writing a history book. PB has been wound down in many places where it was transformational. In many places where it is still being ramped up it is far from transformational. Engaging the poorest and hardest to reach

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sectors of society is a high bar, and often proves difficult (Grillos, 2017). But we should also not confuse softening of the waves with a change in the tide. The positive effects of participation are likely cumulative. This is why it is so important to make sure we know how they happen.

Even if PB morphs as it travels, the aims of its core design are important to keep in mind because they sought to overcome issues of very simplified audience democracy. We should be mindful when designing democratic innovations, in particular where we are engaging a microcosm of the population, that we are also communicating in innovative democratic ways with the wider demos. PB's approach to mass mobilization has shown in some instances the possibilities where hard work on that dimension of buttressing democracy pays off. PB cannot fix everything, even at a local level, and its impact on real transformational outcomes towards a participatory public culture cannot easily be judged. However, it is a significant innovation and does drive us further in the right direction. Many participatory experiments will fail. What I have tried to do here is show the contexts in which important conditions will combine to explain this failure or to explain success. Policymakers and activists will want to take note of the evidence. If you are sitting at home in your city right now, wondering what steps to take to improve citizen participation, what should I tell you?

First, set your expectations. Politics is hard, and while we should aim for the stars, falling short is not the end of participation. If we try to sell clear failures as successes, we are only kidding ourselves (Ryan and Spada, 2017). It is better that we are transparent about the uncertainty with which we operate. But the evidence is clear. You can make participation work in your city or neighbourhood. You may need patience, and you will need representative political leadership committed to participation over the longer term, but successes have come in multiple contexts.

Second, keep informed. One of the reasons PB has been most well received in the academic literature is that it does not shut out interest from those studying development, political economy, area studies scholars, public administration, local government studies, and so on. My point is not that we should all know everything about these diverse literatures; it is more so that academics tend to silo and are the poorer for it. Data collection, methodologies and the creative ideas of normative theorists are improving all the time. Social science can actually help solve problems in the world. Some academics working in this field can actually lay claim to positive impacts!

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Third, try to engender the conditions for multiple key actors to support programmes. In particular, bureaucrats and agency staff have been overlooked in some of the literature, and they tend to appear as important INUS conditions in explanations. But you cannot focus on one variable alone. The analysis and theory both suggest it is certain conjunctions like participatory political leadership and bureaucratic buy-in to participation that produce participatory programmes where authority is transferred from representatives to citizens.

Fourth, be patient and do not scorn middling outcomes so easily. Contradictory outcomes may not always spell doom either. Sometimes democratic behaviour emerges because processes seem to break down (Baiocchi and Ganuza, 2016: 138). We do not know what the long-term distal impact of these projects is yet. Our concepts still need refinement and our causal theories are still uncertain. Changes in power relationships are still difficult to achieve but worth it. Keep going.

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